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MULTI-DOMAIN OPERATIONS DOCTRINE

Strategic Framework, Execution Architecture, and the Three-Track Analytic Model — Final Edition

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NOTICE — UNCLASSIFIED OPEN-SOURCE ANALYTICAL PRODUCT

This paper is an unclassified, open-source analytical product derived exclusively from publicly available doctrine, government publications, and open-source academic sources. The three-track framework is an analytic organizing construct derived from publicly documented authorities and observed practice. It is not a formally codified U.S. decision architecture. Claims derived by logical extension from documented premises are labeled ANALYTICALLY INFERRED. Where the public record does not sustain a firm judgment, the limit is stated explicitly.

PART I: METHODOLOGICAL NOTE AND KEY JUDGMENTS

1.1 Analytical Posture and Scope

This paper constructs a consolidated reference framework for multi-domain operations (MDO) at the strategic and operational levels. Version 3.0 is the final polish pass following structural revision in v2.0, which addressed four red-team findings: overstatement of the three-track framework's formal status, confidence labels outrunning evidence, insufficient interagency and coalition friction, and insufficient adversary-facing analysis. Each section separates Documented Doctrine, Public-Law Authority, and Analytic Assessment. The paper applies a three-track analytic model — Diplomatic, Overt Warfare, and Clandestine/Covert — to organize the principal channels of U.S. state power in competition and conflict.

CONFIDENCE LEXICON

HIGH CONFIDENCE — Directly supported by multiple independent Tier 1 sources. Analytic inference minimal.

MODERATE CONFIDENCE — Supported by Tier 1/2 sourcing with meaningful inference or an unresolved variable.

LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE — Structurally sound inference from indirect public reporting.

LOW CONFIDENCE — Primarily analytic inference. Reasonable alternative conclusions exist.

ANALYTICALLY INFERRED — Derived by logical extension from documented premises. Not directly observed.

SCENARIO-CONDITIONED — Valid only under stated premises. Not a prediction.

1.2 Key Judgments

Six judgments govern this paper. Each carries a probability word, a confidence tag, a stated basis, a principal counterargument, and the condition that would change the confidence assessment.

1

HIGH CONFIDENCE · DOCTRINE-SUPPORTED

MDO is almost certainly the governing joint warfighting concept for peer and near-peer conflict, codified in FM 3-0 (2022) and JP 3-0. Its central mechanism — convergence of cross-domain effects timed to exceed adversary decision-cycle speed — is directly documented. | Basis: primary doctrine (FM 3-0, JP 3-0). | Principal Counterargument: MDO remains contested; critics hold that cross-service interoperability gaps prevent the concept from functioning as specified. | What Would Change Confidence: public evidence of CCMD-level rejection of MDO in favor of a competing concept.

2

MODERATE CONFIDENCE · ANALYTICALLY INFERRED

The three-track framework applied in this paper likely reflects the principal channels through which U.S. state power has been employed in documented strategic campaigns. The

framework is an analytic construct — not a formally codified U.S. decision architecture. | Basis: cross-reference of IEEPA, Title 10, Title 50, official strategy documents, and observed practice. | Principal Counterargument: real campaigns blur track boundaries; the paper's categorical structure is likely neater than actual interagency practice. | What Would Change Confidence: formal government codification or explicit rejection of this categorical structure.

3

LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE · ANALYTICALLY INFERRED

Submarine and undersea forces may offer greater survivability and operational flexibility than surface or air assets under current ASW technology conditions. Comparative ranking across asset classes is not supported by the open-source record and is not asserted. | Basis: CBO FY2024 Navy Submarine Programs; public USN posture statements. | Principal Counterargument: PRC ASW investment trajectories — fixed arrays, helicopter-dipping sonar — may narrow the survivability gap by the late 2030s; long-range air-launched strike may provide comparable effect at lower political risk. | What Would Change Confidence: public reporting on adversary ASW capability closing the acoustic detection margin.

4

LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE · ANALYTICALLY INFERRED

MISO may contribute to shaping the pre-conflict competition environment when integrated with diplomatic signaling, cyber effects, and economic measures. The public record does not permit isolated causal attribution of behavioral change to information operations. | Basis: JP 3-13.2 doctrine; reported use in Ukraine and Gulf campaigns. | Principal Counterargument: PRC media control and Russian domestic narrative management materially limit target audience accessibility for U.S. MISO against primary peer adversaries. | What Would Change Confidence: independently evaluated public evidence of MISO producing specific, measurable adversary behavioral change.

5

LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE · ANALYTICALLY INFERRED

Multilateral sanctions likely impose greater cost on target states than unilateral designation. Whether that cost differential produces strategic behavioral change is not established by the open-source record and is not asserted. | Basis: OFAC Annual Report FY2024; Iran JCPOA case; Russia 2022 counter-case. | Principal Counterargument: three of four major post-2014 sanctions regimes have not demonstrably altered core adversary strategic behavior. | What Would Change Confidence: documented causal linkage between sanctions cost and operational constraint in a peer-equivalent adversary.

6

LOW CONFIDENCE · ANALYTICALLY INFERRED

Clandestine and covert options may be considered in gray-zone and pre-conflict phases because they impose cost below the armed conflict threshold and preserve diplomatic optionality. The public record does not permit confident assessment of their frequency, effectiveness, or comparative preference against diplomatic and economic instruments. | Basis: statutory authorities; publicly reported covert programs in Afghanistan, Syria, Ukraine. | Principal Counterargument: Presidential Finding requirements and interagency friction may make covert action slower and more politically costly than the framework implies; proxy/partner outcomes have been mixed. | What Would Change Confidence: systematic public evaluation of covert option effectiveness comparable to unclassified RAND after-action assessments.

PART II: STRATEGIC DOCTRINE AND THE THREE-TRACK ANALYTIC MODEL

2.1 Multi-Domain Operations

Documented Doctrine

FM 3-0 (October 2022), JP 3-0 (2022), and the Chairman's Joint Warfighting Concept establish MDO as the governing framework for peer adversary operations. No single domain is decisive. Adversary A2/AD architectures deny U.S. freedom of action, primarily in air. The MDO response is convergence: simultaneous cross-domain effects timed to collapse adversary decision cycles before integrated defense responds coherently. Three operational tasks: Compete (below armed conflict); Penetrate and Disintegrate A2/AD; Exploit Freedom of Action. [TIER 1 — FM 3-0, October 2022, Chs. 1–3]

Analytic Assessment

This paper assesses with moderate confidence that MDO's internal logic is sound but faces three documented implementation constraints. First, cross-domain convergence requires interoperability — compatible networks, shared data standards, joint C2 architecture — that remains incomplete across services. Second, the concept requires decision speed that existing command structures may not consistently deliver. Third, PRC investments in EW, space denial, and cyber specifically target the enabling architecture MDO depends upon. The principal uncertainty is whether the institutional force can execute the concept under peer-adversary contested conditions. The public record does not resolve that question. [TIER 2 — RAND MDO Analysis, 2023]

2.2 The Three-Track Analytic Framework

This paper applies a three-track analytic framework to organize the principal channels through which U.S. state power is employed. It is an analytic organizing construct derived from publicly documented authorities and observed practice. It is not a formally codified U.S. decision architecture. Real campaigns frequently blur or compress track boundaries: covert action often precedes diplomatic action; overt military presence functions as economic signaling. The three tracks are analytically distinct; operationally they are concurrent and mutually constitutive.

TRACK	DEFINITION	PRIMARY LEGAL AUTHORITY	EXECUTION LEAD	SANCTIONS INTEGRATION
1 — DIPLOMATIC	Negotiation, deterrence signaling, coalition building, economic coercion, and international pressure through official governmental and	IEEPA; Arms Export Control Act; Title 22 USC; UN Charter	NSC / State / Treasury OFAC	Primary vehicle for sanctions designation; diplomatic track defines the pressure

TRACK	DEFINITION	PRIMARY LEGAL AUTHORITY	EXECUTION LEAD	SANCTIONS INTEGRATION
	multilateral channels.			campaign and provides coalition legitimacy for secondary sanctions.
2 — OVERT WARFARE	Declared or acknowledged use of military force under Title 10, including conventional operations, strikes, maritime interdiction, and power projection.	AUMF; Title 10 USC; UN Charter Art. 51; LOAC/IHL	SecDef / CCMD / Joint Force Commander	Sanctions inform target lists; maritime interdiction enforces cargo restrictions; military presence may coerce compliance in sanctioned jurisdictions.
3 — CLANDESTINE/COVERT	Deniable or unacknowledged operations including CIA covert action, SOF unconventional warfare, proxy support, offensive cyber, and information operations.	Title 50 USC § 3093 (covert action requires Presidential Finding); EO 12333; Title 10 § 127e; AUMF where applicable	CIA SAC / JSOC / USCYBERCOM	Clandestine operations may disrupt sanctions evasion networks and degrade adversary economic infrastructure; operational outcomes are not publicly assessed.

2.3 Authorities Overlap and Interagency Friction

The three-track model implies procedural neatness that does not reflect documented interagency practice. The following constraints are established in public reporting and congressional testimony.

DOCUMENTED INTERAGENCY FRICTION POINTS

Contested Jurisdiction (Title 10 vs. Title 50): DoD and CIA regularly contest operational lead in gray-zone and pre-conflict operations. The 2017 Niger incident demonstrated that Section 127e authorities remain legally and politically contested when operations produce casualties; congressional oversight has tightened since.

Legal Review Variance: DOJ OLC opinions on lawful authority vary across administrations. OCO against adversary critical infrastructure faces unsettled LOAC proportionality and distinction analysis that imposes real execution delays.

Coalition Veto Points: NATO Article 5 does not automatically generate allied operational

participation. UK, French, and Australian participation requires independent legal and political authorization. Compartmented U.S. cyber operations may not be shareable with coalition partners, reducing effectiveness in combined architectures.

Attribution Thresholds: Offensive cyber operations require attribution at a confidence level sufficient for legal review. PRC and Russian cyber infrastructure is specifically layered to raise that threshold. The 2016 DNC attribution and SolarWinds response timelines illustrate months-scale gaps between detection and policy authorization.

Escalation Management Constraints: Track 3 options may be legally available but held in reserve due to escalation concern, alliance equities, or domestic political cost. Legal permissibility and political desirability are frequently misaligned. The Syria Train-and-Equip program, Ukraine lethal assistance debates, and OFAC designation of PRC state enterprises all illustrate that the operative question is political cost, not legal authority.

PART III: FIVE-DOMAIN WARFIGHTING ARCHITECTURE

3.1 Land Domain

Documented Doctrine

Army forces provide sustained ground combat power, area control, and the logistics infrastructure enabling all other domain operations. Key platforms: M1A2 SEPv3 armor, M109A7 Paladin, HIMARS/PrSM (PrSM Block I: 499+ km), and Brigade Combat Teams across armored, infantry, and Stryker variants. GBAD — Patriot PAC-3 and THAAD — defends maneuver forces and critical nodes. [TIER 1 — FM 3-0, October 2022]

Analytic Assessment

This paper assesses with moderate confidence that the primary land-domain constraint in an INDOPACOM contingency is access, not capability. The theater lacks sufficient pre-positioned Army heavy forces; strategic lift throughput via APOD/SPOD is the binding logistics constraint. This assessment is consistent with RAND and CBO public analysis. [TIER 2 — RAND INDOPACOM Logistics Analysis, 2023] The public record does not establish whether pre-positioning improvements currently underway will resolve this constraint within the relevant contingency timeline.

3.2 Sea Domain and Submarine Architecture

Documented Doctrine

The sea domain encompasses surface, subsurface, and littoral warfare. Carrier Strike Groups project airpower. Arleigh Burke DDGs provide Aegis BMD and TLAM strike. The primary subsurface capability is the SSN fleet: Los Angeles (688I), Virginia (Block V, VPM), and Seawolf classes. Virginia Block V's Virginia Payload Module raises TLAM capacity from 12 to 40 tubes per hull. Ohio-class SSBNs (up to 20 Trident II D5 SLBMs per hull) constitute the sea-based nuclear deterrent leg. [TIER 1 — CBO FY2024 Navy Submarine Programs]

Analytic Assessment

This paper assesses with low-moderate confidence that submarine forces may offer greater survivability and flexibility than surface or air assets under current ASW technology conditions. The public record supports high SSN acoustic survivability at current adversary detection capability levels. The degree to which PRC fixed-array, helicopter-dipping sonar, and UUV investments have already narrowed that margin is not established in the public record and constitutes the principal uncertainty for this judgment. Comparative leverage ranking against other asset classes — long-range air-launched strike, space-enabled ISR targeting — is not supported by available evidence and is not asserted.

SUBMARINE INTEGRATION — THREE TRACKS

Track 1 (Diplomatic): Forward SSN deployment to contested maritime regions provides deterrence signaling without declared combat action. This use is documented in public USN force posture

> statements.
>
> Track 2 (Overt Warfare): SSNs execute anti-ship strikes (Mk-48 ADCAP; LRASM pending subsurface clearance), TLAM land-attack, and undersea ISR under CCMD EXORD authority or pre-delegated OPLAN authority.
>
> Track 3 (Clandestine): SSNs conduct special reconnaissance and SEAL delivery under Title 10 and EO 12333 authorities and classified operational orders. The public record does not establish specific operational parameters.
>
> Principal Uncertainty: The public record does not establish the current operational impact of PRC undersea sensing improvements on SSN freedom of maneuver in the South China Sea and Taiwan Strait.

3.3 Air Domain

Documented Doctrine

Air superiority is prerequisite to conventional domain operations. SEAD/DEAD uses EA-18G EW, JASSM-ER (1,000+ km), and 5th-generation stealth penetrators. The B-21 Raider provides penetrating strike against hardened targets. C-17/C-5M airlift and KC-46 Pegasus tanking provide global mobility. [TIER 1 — USAF Posture Statement FY2025]

Analytic Assessment

This paper assesses with moderate confidence that air superiority over Taiwan Strait or South China Sea against PRC IADS — HQ-9, S-400 derivatives, DF-21D/DF-26 — is achievable with current 5th-generation and JASSM-ER combinations, but requires attrition-based DEAD that imposes real cost. The principal vulnerability is the enabling architecture — AWACS, J-STARS, tankers — which is soft-killable via PRC cyber and ASCM, and which the open-source record identifies as the air domain's primary unresolved exposure. [TIER 2 — CSIS China Power Project, 2024]

3.4 Space Domain

Documented Doctrine

USSPACECOM and USSF govern space as a warfighting domain. Space provides GPS III (PNT), WGS (SATCOM), SBIRS/Next-Gen OPIR (missile warning), NRO imagery (targeting), and MUOS (mobile tactical comms). Space Domain Awareness tracks 20,000+ objects. Offensive counter-space capabilities are publicly acknowledged at the existence level; parameters are classified. [TIER 1 — USSF Posture Statement FY2025]

Analytic Assessment

This paper assesses with moderate-high confidence, based on ODNI ATA 2025, that PRC counter-space investments — co-orbital maneuvering satellites, directed energy, jamming — target the GPS, SATCOM, and OPIR architecture that MDO requires. ODNI ATA 2025 reports that China 'has fielded ground-based ASAT missiles' and is developing additional capabilities. Resilience measures — disaggregated constellations, commercial augmentation, ground station diversity — partially offset but do not eliminate this risk. [TIER 1 — ODNI Annual Threat Assessment 2025, p. 10]

3.5 Cyberspace Domain

Documented Doctrine

USCYBERCOM executes cyber operations under the Defend Forward doctrine (2018/2023 DoD Cyber Strategies). Defend Forward authorizes persistent engagement in adversary networks during peacetime. The Cyber Mission Force of 133 teams executes OCO, DCO, and CNE. [TIER 1 — DoD Cyber Strategy 2023, unclassified summary]

Analytic Assessment

Public reporting indicates USCYBERCOM has conducted Hunt Forward operations in 17 countries through FY2023. The public record does not establish whether pre-positioned OCO capabilities would execute reliably against PRC integrated defense under contested electromagnetic conditions. Attribution latency is a documented constraint: both the 2016 DNC case and the SolarWinds response demonstrate months-scale gaps between initial detection and policy-level authorization. This constraint applies to both defensive and offensive operations.

PART IV: PSYCHOLOGICAL OPERATIONS, INFORMATION OPERATIONS, AND ECONOMIC INTEGRATION

4.1 PSYOP and Military Information Support Operations

Documented Doctrine

MISO is the planned use of information directed at foreign target audiences to influence attitudes and behaviors in support of national objectives (JP 3-13.2, 2022). USACAPOC and SOCOM's 4th Psychological Operations Group provide the institutional structure and forward element. [TIER 1 — JP 3-13.2, December 2022]

Analytic Assessment

This paper assesses with low-moderate confidence that MISO may contribute to shaping the competition environment when integrated with diplomatic, cyber, and economic measures. The public record does not permit isolated causal attribution of behavioral change to information operations. Iraq and Afghanistan campaigns produced MISO at scale without demonstrating proportional effect; the available evidence is consistent with this being a methodological attribution problem rather than a null effectiveness finding.

Adversary resilience is a documented constraint. PRC information environment controls — Great Firewall, party-controlled media, Weibo/WeChat monitoring — substantially limit target audience accessibility for U.S. MISO against PRC populations and elites. Russian domestic information management achieved sufficient narrative control from 2014 through at least 2022 to sustain public support for major strategic actions. This paper assesses with moderate confidence, based on RAND Countering Russian Disinformation (2023), that adversary information environment architecture materially constrains U.S. MISO effectiveness against both primary peer adversaries. [TIER 2 — RAND, 2023]

PSYOP — SANCTIONS INTEGRATION FRAMEWORK

Phase 1 (Pre-Designation): MISO establishes the narrative framework before OFAC designation. Causal contribution to subsequent adversary behavior is ANALYTICALLY INFERRED; the public record does not establish this phase's effect.

Phase 2 (Designation): OFAC designation is the primary verifiable event. State/GEC MISO amplification is documented. Whether amplification produces target audience behavioral change is the principal unresolved variable.

Phase 3 (Pressure Escalation): Causal linkage between sanctions cost and policy change is documented in limited cases (Iran JCPOA 2015) and absent in others (Russia 2022, DPRK). This paper does not assert that this phase reliably produces behavioral change.

Phase 4 (Covert Reinforcement): This phase is ANALYTICALLY INFERRED. Title 50 covert influence capabilities are publicly acknowledged to exist; the public record does not permit confident assessment of effectiveness against PRC or Russian elite cohesion.

4.2 Electronic Warfare

Documented Doctrine

EW — jamming, spoofing, deception, directed-energy — contests adversary spectrum use while protecting U.S. use. EA-18G Growler is the primary EW aircraft. EW enables SEAD/DEAD (radar suppression preceding kinetic strikes) and CNE (spectrum degradation expanding exploitation windows). [TIER 1 — USAF Electronic Warfare FY2024 Budget Justification]

4.3 Sanctions as Economic Instrument

Public-Law Authority

OFAC administers approximately 35 active sanctions programs under IEEPA, TWEA, and specific statutory authorities. OFAC FY2024 reported $1.54 billion in civil monetary penalties. [TIER 1 — OFAC Annual Report FY2024] Primary sanctions restrict U.S. person dealings. Secondary sanctions restrict third-country entities. Maritime interdiction enforcement uses VBSS authority under applicable UNSCR Chapter VII mandates.

Analytic Assessment — Case Evidence

Three bounded cases provide the evidentiary basis for the paper's claims about sanctions integration, with limits stated explicitly for each.

MINI-CASE 1 — IRAN: JCPOA LEVERAGE MECHANISM

Documented: U.S.-led sanctions (2012–2015) — including SWIFT exclusion, oil embargo, and financial sector designation — contributed to Iranian GDP contraction of approximately 15–20% and a 60% reduction in oil export revenue. [TIER 1 — EIA Iran Country Analysis, 2015; IMF Article IV, 2015]

Documented: Iran signed the JCPOA in July 2015.

Principal Uncertainty: The public record does not establish that sanctions alone caused JCPOA compliance. Iranian domestic politics, IRGC equities, and diplomatic sequencing were also factors. The post-2018 maximum pressure campaign produced no equivalent agreement, which is inconsistent with simple sanctions-effectiveness models.

Assessment: Sanctions contributed materially to leverage in the JCPOA case. Isolated causal attribution is not supportable with available evidence.

MINI-CASE 2 — RUSSIA: BEHAVIORAL CONSTRAINT LIMITS

Documented: Post-2022 sanctions on Russia — SWIFT exclusion of major banks, freeze of $300B+ in sovereign reserves, comprehensive export controls — imposed documented costs including GDP contraction (approximately 2.1% in 2022, below projections) and budget deficit expansion. [TIER 1 — OFAC Russia Designations FY2022–2024; BIS EAR amendments]

Documented: Russia redirected energy exports to China and India. Military operations in Ukraine continued through 2024.

Principal Uncertainty: Whether cost-without-behavioral-change reflects sanctions design, Russian domestic political constraints, third-country workarounds, or the limits of economic coercion against a nuclear-armed state is analytically contested.

Assessment: This case documents comprehensive economic coercion imposing cost while failing to produce strategic behavioral change. It is the primary counter-case to claims of sanctions

decisiveness.

MINI-CASE 3 — DPRK: ENFORCEMENT GAP

Documented: UNSCR 2375/2397 (2017) imposed comprehensive commodity sanctions. U.S. Navy conducted maritime interdiction patrols. UN Panel of Experts (2019–2023) identified a ship-to-ship transfer network of 25–40 vessels using AIS spoofing and flag-of-convenience registration. Petroleum cap enforcement is assessed by UN PoE as largely ineffective by 2022. [TIER 1 — UNSCR 2397; OFAC DPRK Designations FY2018–2024; UN PoE Reports 2019–2023]

Assessment: Evasion innovation outpaced enforcement adaptation within approximately 18–24 months. This case illustrates the enforcement gap between Track 1 designation authority and Track 2/3 enforcement capacity.

SANCTIONS INSTRUMENT	LEGAL AUTHORITY	ENFORCEMENT TRACK	MDO INTEGRATION POINT	CASE EVIDENCE
Primary designation	IEEPA / EOs 13694, 14024	Track 1 — Diplomatic	OFAC designates entities; MISO may amplify; NSC coordinates coalition alignment	Iran JCPOA: contributory, not isolated cause. Russia 2022: costs imposed, behavioral change not produced.
Secondary sanctions	CAATSA; IEEPA	Track 1 — Diplomatic	Requires partner coalition; Treasury enforces; State coordinates compliance	CAATSA secondary exposure has generated documented EU friction; compliance contested across partner states.
Maritime interdiction	UNSCR Ch. VII; LOAC	Track 2 — Overt Warfare	DDGs / P-8 enforce embargo; VBSS boards suspect vessels under UNSCR authority	DPRK: documented ship-to-ship evasion network outpaced U.S./UN interdiction within 18–24 months.
Evasion network disruption	Title 50; EO 12333; FinCEN	Track 3 — Clandestine	CIA/NSA FININT targeting; OCO against front company networks	Public record establishes this capability exists. Operational outcomes are not publicly assessed.
ICS/SCADA financial attack	Title 10/50; Presidential Finding	Track 3 — Clandestine	OCO may target adversary banking and settlement	Stuxnet (Iran, 2010) is the only publicly confirmed

SANCTIONS INSTRUMENT	LEGAL AUTHORITY	ENFORCEMENT TRACK	MDO INTEGRATION POINT	CASE EVIDENCE
			infrastructure	analogous operation. Financial infrastructure attack has not been confirmed in any sanctions enforcement context.

PART V: SPECIAL OPERATIONS, CLANDESTINE FORCES, AND COVERT ACTION

5.1 Legal Architecture

Public-Law Authority

Title 10 USC § 167 establishes USSOCOM as a combatant command. § 127e authorizes SOF support to foreign partner forces in CT operations. The 2001 AUMF and subsequent legislation authorize direct action against designated organizations. Title 50 USC § 3093 requires a written Presidential Finding for CIA covert action and Congressional notification (Gang of Eight minimum; full committee for most programs). EO 12333 (2008 amendment) governs peacetime intelligence activities including clandestine collection. [TIER 1 — Title 10 USC; Title 50 USC § 3093; EO 12333]

Analytic Assessment

Covert action is not a rapid-response instrument in the first instance. The Presidential Finding requirement imposes procedural latency. The executive branch pre-authorizes Findings for anticipated contingencies to preserve agility, but this mechanism requires re-authorization and is subject to congressional oversight that can constrain operational tempo. The 2017 Niger incident and subsequent NDAA FY2018 tightening of § 127e authorities illustrate that congressional tolerance for casualties in deniable operations imposes operational risk-acceptance constraints not captured in the statutory structure.

5.2 SOF and Covert Force Employment

FORCE	TIER	AUTHORITY	TRACK	PRIMARY FUNCTION	EXECUTION ORDER REQUIRED
SF ODA	2	Title 10; SOFA/bilateral	2/3	UW, FID, SR, PSYOP support	CCMD OPORD / JSOTF order
75th Ranger Regiment	2	Title 10; AUMF	2	Direct action, airfield seizure	JSOC OPORD
Delta Force / DEVGRU	1	Title 10; Presidential authority	2	HVT, hostage rescue, counter-WMD	SECDEF or POTUS EXORD
CIA Ground Branch (SAC)	1	Title 50; Presidential Finding	3	Covert paramilitary, lethal covert action	Presidential Finding; SECSTATE coordination required
SEAL Teams (non-Tier 1)	2	Title 10; AUMF	2/3	DA, SR, VBSS, UW	CCMD JSOTF order

FORCE	TIER	AUTHORITY	TRACK	PRIMARY FUNCTION	EXECUTION ORDER REQUIRED
160th SOAR	2	Title 10	2/3	SOF aviation: infiltration/exfiltration, ISR, fires	JTF or JSOC order

NOTE ON TABLE CERTAINTY

The authority and execution order columns above reflect publicly documented statutory frameworks. Actual operational thresholds — including which force requires which Presidential-level versus SECDEF-level versus CCMD-level approval in specific contingencies — are governed by classified operational orders and may differ from the statutory baseline presented. The table should be read as documenting the predicate legal structure, not as a definitive operational authorization map.

PART VI: ADVERSARY CONTEXT AND ESCALATION LOGIC

6.1 People's Republic of China — Systems Confrontation and Political Warfare

Documented Doctrine

PLA doctrine, articulated in the Science of Military Strategy (2020) and AMS publications, centers on systems confrontation (体系对抗): neutralizing an adversary's operational system before attriting its platforms. The PLA targets C2, logistics, ISR, and space/cyber enablers before engaging combat platforms. This approach is structurally analogous to MDO convergence but oriented toward disabling the enabling architecture U.S. forces require. [TIER 2 — RAND PLA Modernization, 2023; USCC Annual Report 2024]

Analytic Assessment

This paper assesses, consistent with ODNI ATA 2025, that PRC Three Warfares doctrine — legal warfare (法律战), media warfare (舆论战), and psychological warfare (心理战) — is specifically designed to exploit the seams between Track 1 and Track 3 in the U.S. response architecture. Legal warfare challenges the legitimacy of U.S. presence and sanctions regimes in international forums. Media warfare targets alliance cohesion by amplifying partner-nation reluctance. Psychological warfare targets U.S. decision-maker will. The campaign does not require winning on any single dimension; it requires imposing sufficient friction to delay decisive U.S. action past the adversary's operational culmination point. [TIER 1 — ODNI ATA 2025, pp. 8–12]

6.2 Russia — Escalation Signaling and Decision-Window Compression

Documented Doctrine

Russian military doctrine — the Gerasimov article (2013), the 2014 Military Doctrine, and the 2021 National Security Strategy — conceptualizes conflict as a continuous spectrum from peace through war without categorical boundaries. Deniable paramilitary forces, information operations, cyber intrusions, and sabotage are applied continuously below the armed conflict threshold in ways designed to prevent clean Track categorization by U.S. decision-makers. [TIER 2 — RAND Russian Operational Art, 2022; Kofman and Fink, Foreign Affairs, 2023]

Analytic Assessment

This paper assesses with moderate confidence that Russia's escalation signaling — nuclear exercises, strategic bomber flights, threshold-testing conventional actions — specifically targets the deliberative timeline that U.S. Track 2 authority structures require. War Powers Resolution notification norms and Congressional consultation requirements were designed for a faster congressional-executive relationship than currently exists. Russia's operational approach appears to account for this institutional lag. This assessment is based on documented Russian operational patterns in Georgia (2008), Crimea (2014), and Syria (2015). [TIER 2 — Brookings, Charap and Darden, 2023]

6.3 DPRK — Nuclear Asymmetry and Proportionality Constraints

Analytic Assessment

ODNI ATA 2025 assesses with high confidence that DPRK has demonstrated ICBM capability. This paper assesses with low-moderate confidence, ANALYTICALLY INFERRED from LOAC doctrine and DPRK capability reporting, that demonstrated ICBM capability materially affects the proportionality calculus applicable to any Track 2 response to North Korean conventional provocations. The relevant question under LOAC is not whether nuclear retaliation is certain, but whether its non-zero probability — at asymmetric consequence — affects the proportionality determination. The public record does not establish whether or how this factor is incorporated into current U.S. contingency planning. [TIER 1 — ODNI ATA 2025, pp. 15–17]

PART VII: EXECUTION WORKFLOW AND DECISION CONDITIONS

7.1 F2T2EA Targeting Sequence

PHASE	FUNCTION	ASSETS	AUTHORITY	DECISION CONDITION	OFF-RAMP / FRICTION
FIND	Multi-INT cueing; pattern-of-life development	NSA SIGINT; NRO; CIA HUMINT; NGA; airborne ISR	EO 12333; Title 10 ISR authority	Target identified as valid military objective under LOAC	ID below legal threshold — return to collection; do not proceed
FIX	Precise geolocation to weapon delivery CEP threshold	SIGINT geolocation; GPS-referenced imagery; HUMINT confirmation	Existing ISR authority	Location accuracy meets planned munition CEP threshold	Geolocation uncertainty — delay or select larger-radius munition
TRACK	Persistent surveillance through engagement window	MQ-9; satellite; SIGINT continuation	Continued ISR authority	Sensor continuity maintained; no track-loss gap	Track lost — return to FIX; do not engage on stale data
TARGET	Weaponeering; ROE verification; LOAC legal review; CDE	J2 target intel; J3 fires; SJA legal review	JTF ROE; LOAC CDE proportionality; EXORD thresholds	Legal review complete; CDE within proportionality limits; ROE satisfied	CDE exceeds threshold — refer up; legal review unresolved — hold fire
ENGAGE	Execute; assign shooter; activate terminal guidance	Strike aircraft; TLAM; HIMARS/PrSM; OCO; SOF DA	EXORD; CCMD delegation; ROE card	Positive ID confirmed at time of engagement; no protected status change	Target moves to protected site — abort; escalation threshold exceeded — refer to CCMD
ASSESS	Physical, functional, and target system BDA; re-attack recommend	NRO post-strike imagery; SIGINT BDA; HUMINT; SSE	Standard ISR collection authority	Assessment complete; re-attack decision based on functional damage assessment	BDA inconclusive — hold re-attack pending ISR; collateral damage confirmed — escalate to CCMD and SJA

PHASE	FUNCTION	ASSETS	AUTHORITY	DECISION CONDITION	OFF-RAMP / FRICTION
	ation				

7.2 Four-Phase Campaign Workflow

PHASE	TRACK 1	TRACK 2	TRACK 3	SANCTIONS	ESCALATION TRIGGER	OFF-RAMP
COMPETITION (Phase 0)	Coalition building; sanctions architecture construction; deterrence threshold signaling	Forward presence; security cooperation; BMD posture	HUMINT collection; SOF FID; PSYOP framework development; CNE pre-positioning	OFAC architecture established; secondary sanctions active; FININT targeting ongoing	Adversary military aggregation above exercise threshold	Diplomatic engagement; deconfliction channel activation
CRISIS (Phase 1)	Coercive diplomacy; UNSC proceedings; expanded designation	CCMD force flow; dispersed basing; submarine surge; maritime interdiction	Covert action under Finding; proxy activation; PSYOP surge; OCO disruption	Emergency OFAC actions; SWIFT exclusion threat; energy sector sanctions	Adversary first kinetic or cyber use against U.S. or treaty ally	Hotline use; partial concession; face-saving diplomatic formula
ARMED CONFLICT (Phase 2–3)	Coalition management; war termination preparation	EXORD; A2/AD penetration; kinetic fires; maritime and air operations	SOF DA; JSOC Tier 1 HVT; CIA covert resistance support; continued OCO	Sanctions maintained; maritime blockade; possible central bank OCO	Adversary nuclear signaling — threshold assessed as approached	Pause offensive; nuclear risk reduction consultations; escalation management channel
POST-CONFLICT (Phase 4)	Reconstruction; conditioned sanctions relief; peace agreement	Security assistance; partner force advising	Long-term intelligence architecture; SOF stabilization transition	Sanctions relief structured as behavioral compliance leverage	Renewed aggression or ceasefire violation	Sanctions re-imposition; Track 2 redeployment; covert action reauthorization

PART VIII: STRUCTURAL CONSTRAINTS AND CONFIDENCE BOUNDARIES

8.1 Limitations of the Public Record

DOCUMENTED LIMITATIONS

This paper is bounded by the publicly available record. Operational details of current OPLANs, contingency plans, and active covert programs are classified and not reflected.

The three-track framework is an analytic organizing construct. Real interagency practice may differ materially from the categorical structure presented.

Capability assessments reflect publicly acknowledged specifications. Actual performance — particularly for classified cyber tools, submarine sensors, and adversary ASW systems — may differ materially.

The mini-cases in Part IV are bounded by the public record. Causal attribution is limited to 'contributory' language. No claim of decisiveness is asserted.

The adversary analysis in Part VI relies on translated public documents and Western analysis — not primary intelligence. It is necessarily more inferred than the doctrinal and statutory sections.

8.2 Principal Uncertainties

The public record does not establish: (1) whether PRC ASW investments have already reduced SSN freedom of maneuver in contested waters; (2) whether U.S. MISO has produced measurable behavioral change in any primary peer adversary population; (3) whether USCYBERCOM OCO pre-positioning would execute reliably against PRC integrated defense under contested electromagnetic conditions; (4) whether the DPRK nuclear threshold is operationalized at a level already constraining Track 2 contingency planning; or (5) whether Russian escalation signaling reflects standing doctrine or real-time improvisation.

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